

resistance, and going above 50 mph significantly decreases your fuel efficiency. According to FuelEconomy.gov, each 5 mph you drive over 50 mph reduces your fuel economy by 20%.

4. Windows vs. air-conditioning

The debate over using the A/C versus having the windows down has to do with how large the effect of drag on a particular car is. Air-conditioning can reduce a conventional vehicle's fuel economy by more than 25%. The drag caused by having windows down on a sedan can go up to 8.5%, while SUVs are only affected by up to 4%. It's generally accepted that when driving at low speeds (under 40 mph), it's better to have the windows down, while efficiency favors the A/C at higher speeds. But when you're driving an SUV, it may not make much of a difference no matter what the speed.

5. Stop idling

You use up gas when your car is on idle (going zero miles will drop your average mpg). This doesn't mean turning off your car in the middle of the road when you're in traffic or at a red light, but keep in mind it's better to turn off your car and restart than to leave it on idle for more than 30

seconds. So if there's a long line at the drive-through, consider parking and walking in.

6. Keep it warm

First, there's no need to warm up the engine before driving. Cars today warm up faster and more efficiently by just driving rather than idling (which wastes gas as mentioned above). Second, plan your errands and drive to the farthest destination first, so your engine can completely warm up. It hurts your engine to make frequent stops (making your engine cool and have to warm up again), especially in cold weather. If you allow your engine time to warm up completely before stopping, there will be less loss of heat and it'll take less time to warm it back up when you go to your next stop.

7. Lose weight

If you're carrying excess pounds in your trunk (no pun intended), get rid of it. Weight contributes to your gas mileage too, so remove any unnecessary load.

Driving efficiently so you can save money at the gas station is great incentive to be more mindful when you drive. But more important, it's a very easy and cheap way to contrib-